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BHASKAR PAUL



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LIFE UNDONE (Clockwise) Taliban militants surround the hijacked Indian Airlines Flight 814 in Kandahar, 1999; Australian missionary Graham Staines being buried with his two sons, 1999; the Osama bin Laden-orchestrated 9/11 attack, 2001

time". One gruesome sign came in 1999, when the Bajrang Dal burned Australian missionary Graham Staines and his two young sons alive. But the higher opprobrium was reserved for the episode that tested statecraft: the oft-dramatised hijacking of IC814 later that year. Still catching its breath on this side of 2000, India saw America rocked with 9/11 and its own Parliament with a fidayeen attack that killed seven security officials and a civilian. Nothing seemed very sacred anymore, least of all social contracts of democracy.

Bookend this age with the smouldering aftermath of the 2002 Godhra train arson which claimed 59 lives and the riots in Gujarat thereafter. It embroiled then-CM Narendra Modi in years of legal challenges—the courts finally cleared him—but also inflected a nation's course. Kashmir, meanwhile, kept up its supply of body bags through the decade: with an insurgency that shot everyone from dissidents to Amarnath pilgrims, and a trigger-happy military that knew best how not to win hearts and influence people. ■



Jehad Against The World
Sept. 24, 2001

"By the third day (after 9/11) of America's biggest manmade disaster, its economic fallout had begun to crystallise. The estimates ranged between a direct loss to the US economy of $30 billion and a total loss of $90 billion (Rs 1,42,500 crore and Rs 4,27,500 crore).... At just 5 per cent the size of the US economy, India's economy will not be so directly impacted.... But the US has a disproportionately important share in India's exports and is the largest foreign investor in the country. If the US economy does slip into a brief recession and pulls down the European and Japanese economies with it, India's already tottering economic growth would be crippled even more."